The Panchatantra is possibly the second-most circulated book ever (behind the Bible). Shiva and Krishna became popular gods only after the Vedic period, displacing Indra, Varuna and Soma. Along with Buddhism and Jainism, the Ajivika tradition was the third major religion to emerge in the fifth century BCE, but did not survive, unlike the other two. These are some of the fascinating mini-stories in *India: 5,000 Years of History on the Subcontinent* by the historian and Rutgers University professor Audrey Truschke.

In this sweeping overview of five millennia, Truschke synthesises existing scholarship into an account that runs from the Indus Valley civilisation to the present. So why did an academic historian venture into popular history?

"I remain convinced that historians can and should write for broad audiences," says Truschke, in an email interview. This book emerged after she was approached by Princeton University Press. "I hope that the book introduces Indian history to an entirely new audience in the United States and contributes to the embattled project to maintain fidelity to history in India."

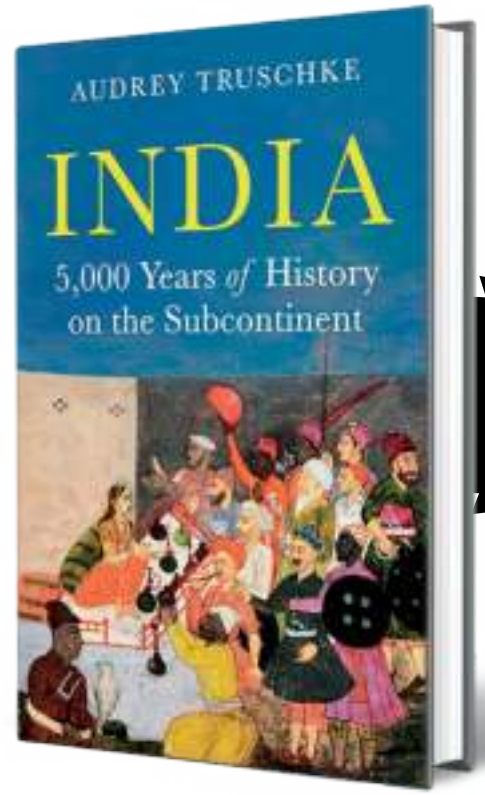
Part of that involves undoing persistent myths about India. For instance, Muslim rulers were not the only ones sacking places of worship, Hindu and Buddhist kings, too, frequently raided sacred sites. Or the idea that subcontinental rule is split into broad periods: Hindu rule until 1200 CE, Muslim rule until the 1750s and, finally, colonial rule. "The Hindu/Muslim/British periodisation of Indian history was designed to make the British look good and was, completely unsurprisingly, invented by the British," she says. "This dichotomy overemphasises the role of religion in Indian history and erases other religions. I think this triptych formulation should be discarded entirely, only mentioned as a point of intellectual history having to do with colonial domination and its long afterlives."

This ambitious narrative is an engaging overview, featuring many familiar dynasties, characters and politics. But part of the effort was to make the telling more inclusive through, Truschke writes, "a greater diversity of voices than we often hear in South Asian history in terms of gender, caste, class, region, language and religion." For instance, southern India gets as much space as the north; we are told that the Cholas were both builders of iconic temples and overseers of harsh slavery practices. We hear about an intercaste and inter-religious event from 1745 near Pondicherry as narrated in the private diary of a Tamilian working for the French East India Company.

"The views, actions and ideas of dominant groups are nearly always more well preserved in the historical record, but I found riches of more diverse voices in Indian history," she says. "In part, I looked to under-used sources and, here, familiarity with the vast literary traditions of pre-modern India was helpful. I also read more well-worn sources against the grain. Such that, for example, I let Manu—a premodern Brahmin patriarch and law theorist—tell readers about his prizing of inequality as the organising feature of a good society. I also read Manu's text through the eyes of those he condemns to lesser status and seeks to oppress, including women and Dalits."

Caste became entrenched in the

ONE OF THE SURPRISES THAT CAME TRUSCHKE'S WAY WAS FINDING OUT THAT THE ROMANTIC STORY BEHIND THE TAJ MAHAL WAS LARGELY TRUE



INDIA
5,000 Years of History on the Subcontinent
By Audrey Truschke
PRINCETON UNIVERSITY PRESS
₹1,299; 712 pages